



OUR BEGINNINGS

Before the COVID-19 pandemic shocked the globe, encouraging socioeconomic progress was being made in Colombia, where the poverty rate was cut by half, to 27%, from 2002 to 2018. However, when COVID-19 reached Colombia, it had dire economic impact. At the time, the COVID-19 crisis was projected to cause the deepest recession in Colombia in more than a century. As it unfolded throughout 2020, at least 1.45 million people were estimated to have fallen into poverty, increasing poverty at least 3% and largely reversing the poverty reduction gains made in recent years, in addition to the 17.5 million already living in poverty before the pandemic.

Articles published by various news organizations showed the environment that children in rural parts of Colombia were living in, causing many to join armed forces, turn to prostitution, or go into the workforce at a very early age. In April 2021, at the height of the pandemic, a proposed labor reform law triggered a wave of protests across Colombia, against increasing poverty, the impact of the pandemic, and accusations of human rights abuses. Youth from working class and underserved neighborhoods had become the majority of frontliners leading the protests.



As we watched all of this unfold, four poderosas in the US and Colombia – Kathy Suarez, Hannah Mora, Johana Suarez, and Claudia Daza – began looking for ways to support nuestra patria, with the desire and curiosity to create positive, transformative, and sustainable solutions that would support those most impacted by the COVID-19 pandemic, and by the systemic issues related to poverty and inequality within the country at large. Quickly, we realized there was a perceived lack of trust with many organizations sending resources to Colombia. We also learned that Colombia is one of the most underfunded countries in the world. Determined to find a way forward, we held our first meeting in May 2021, and Powerful Children Colombia was born.

We started meeting every other week, narrowing down our focus and defining the vision for the project: supporting opportunities for children in Colombia that could provide pathways for them to have fulfilling lives free of poverty, violence and/or exploitation. We knew that we wanted to support locally led efforts – invest in the committed leaders who have been doing the work in their communities all along, and know what their communities need most. We also wanted to invite others to join us, but we knew that there is an understandable lack of trust due to the country's history of corruption and conflict. So, this became an intentional part of our efforts – to identify reliable sources with whom we could work closely with to build awareness and trust between the givers and the doers.



We continued growing our team with passionate individuals based in Colombia – Sandra Liliana Orozco Gomez, a social worker, Julian Mesa, an accountant, and Adriana Suarez – who brought a wealth of insights to our work, both operationally and programmatically. We also received support from Colombians Javier Espinosa, webmaster, and Julicore, who designed our logo.

On January 2022, Powerful Children Colombia was officially recognized as a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization. Our goal is to position Powerful Children Colombia as a leader and trusted source for distributing funds directly to those most in need, connecting donors with Colombian-led organizations to strengthen cultural bonds and increase awareness of the barriers faced by children and their communities on the ground.

Thank you for reading about our beginnings!
To learn more, follow us on [Instagram](#).